

Owen Fernau

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Operations and editorial professional who ran research-coordination infrastructure for a growing newsletter and stepped into de facto chief-of-staff work when the role came open. Five years as a professional writer and editor before that. Making a deliberate transition into AI safety and governance operations.

Experience

Editorial and Operations Lead | OurNetwork (onchain data research organization) Remote [Jan 2024 – Present]
Onchain data research newsletter operated by Mika Holdings, a family office. Started as Editorial Lead, promoted to Editorial and Operations Lead in October 2024 after the Chief of Staff stepped down, gaining 3 direct reports.

- **Research Operations:** Primary liaison to 100+ contributing researchers within a 500+ member analyst community; re-built the outreach system with an active-availability database maintained by a direct report, lifting contributor response rates ~50%
- **De Facto Chief of Staff:** Absorbed leadership-level responsibilities after the Chief of Staff departed, including confidential payroll administration and a 2025 headcount reduction, while managing \$210,000+ in sponsored partnerships across \$1B+ partner networks, from outreach through invoicing
- **Research Communications:** Grew the newsletter from 28,000 to 36,000 subscribers, turning technical onchain research into content read by professionals at Goldman Sachs, J.P. Morgan, and MIT; built data visualizations using Python, Jupyter, and Figma
- **AI-Native Tooling:** Learned Python and Jupyter to absorb a departing developer's data work; builds custom AI-native tools (e.g. a Claude Code-built task-management system used daily) to run day-to-day operations

Lead Reporter | The Defiant Remote [Jan 2021 – Dec 2023]
Crypto-focused media company founded by a Bloomberg News alumnus. Started as Staff Reporter, promoted to Lead Reporter in March 2022 as colleague turnover increased.

- Wrote and edited 750+ articles on daily deadlines, generating 1.5M+ page views and citations in the Harvard Journal of Law and Technology, William and Mary Law Review, and Texas Tech Law Review
- Trained under two Bloomberg News alumni while covering technical and policy developments on tight deadlines
- Remained through high turnover, including recruiting approaches of my own, as colleagues were poached by competitors; mentored incoming reporters while hosting livestreams drawing tens of thousands of views

Research Analyst | TruStory Remote [June 2019 – Dec 2019]
Early-stage startup platform for debating claims, founded by ex-a16z's Preethi Kasireddy.

- Wrote debate content for Reddit to grow platform engagement, and fed user feedback directly into product decisions

Projects & Recognition

Graph (in development): co-building an AI safety community tool pairing agent-facilitated introductions with a personalized research feed; grew the underlying dataset to 3,000+ people while lifting AI-extraction accuracy from 60% to 70%. Awarded a Blue Dot rapid grant for the work (2026)

Front Burner: solo-built task-management system with Claude Code; planned and executed a major data-model migration on a live personal dataset, verifying zero data loss (2026)

Ethereum Foundation Devconnect Scholar, Community Organizers track (1 of ~100 selected; Buenos Aires, 2025)

AI Safety Career Advisee: accepted by both Probably Good and Blue Dot Impact (2026)

Skills

Operations & Data: Python, Jupyter, Airtable, Excel, Google Workspace, Microsoft Office

AI & Automation: Claude Code and other coding agents for internal tools and automating recurring workflows

Design & Web: Figma, Git, basic web development

Education

B.A. Economics, Honors | University of California, Santa Cruz Santa Cruz, CA [2016 – 2020]
Two years of Japanese coursework, study abroad in Tokyo. Certs: Blue Dot Frontier AI Governance & AGI Strategy.